

Past Simple vs Past Continuous

CEFR B1

Lesson Pack · summary, worksheet & answer key

Quick answer

Both are past tenses, but they see the action differently. Use:

- 1 Past simple for a completed action — I cooked dinner.
- 2 Past continuous for an action in progress — I was cooking dinner.
- 3 Together: continuous sets the scene, simple is the event — I was cooking when he arrived.

Longer or background action → past continuous; shorter, completed action or interruption → past simple.

At a glance

	Past Simple	Past Continuous
Action	completed	in progress
Length	the whole action or a short event	a longer, background action
In a story	the events	the scene / setting
Example	The phone rang .	I was sleeping .

Learning objectives

- Can select the past simple or past continuous by aspect — completed versus in progress (CEFR B1).
- Can combine the two to express interrupted and background actions.
- Can explain the meaning difference between the two in a when-clause.



Practice worksheet

Circle the correct option. Past Simple vs Past Continuous · CEFR B1

Name: _____

Date: _____

1. I ____ dinner when the guests arrived.

- A. cooked
- C. cook

- B. was cooking
- D. am cooking

2. When the alarm rang, everyone ____ the building.

- A. was leaving
- C. leaves

- B. left
- D. leave

3. The sun ____ when we woke up.

- A. shone
- C. shines

- B. was shining
- D. shine

4. While I ____ the dishes, I dropped a plate.

- A. washed
- C. wash

- B. was washing
- D. am washing

5. What ____ you ____ when the earthquake struck?

- A. were / doing
- C. was / doing

- B. did / do
- D. are / doing

6. He ____ TV for an hour, then he went to bed.

- A. watched
- C. watches

- B. was watching
- D. watch

7. I ____ to go home early because I felt tired.

- A. was wanting
- C. were wanting

- B. wanted
- D. want

8. They were playing football when it ____ to rain.

- A. was starting
- C. starts

- B. started
- D. start

9. Rewrite with the same meaning: 'During my walk home, a dog suddenly barked at me.'

- A. I walked home and then a dog barked.
- C. A dog barked before my walk home.

- B. I was walking home when a dog suddenly barked at me.
- D. I didn't walk home that day.

10. Which sentence means the cooking was already in progress?

- A. I cooked when he called.
- C. I cook when he calls.

- B. I was cooking when he called.
- D. I will cook when he calls.

Answer key

Correct answers with explanations · for the teacher

1. **B. was cooking** — The cooking was already in progress, so use the past continuous: 'was cooking'.
2. **B. left** — A completed reaction to the alarm takes the past simple: 'left'.
3. **B. was shining** — Setting the scene (an action already in progress) takes the past continuous: 'was shining'.
4. **B. was washing** — 'While' + a longer action in progress takes the past continuous: 'was washing'.
5. **A. were / doing** — Asking about an action in progress at that past moment uses the past continuous: 'were you doing'.
6. **A. watched** — A completed action in a sequence ('then he went to bed') takes the past simple: 'watched'.
7. **B. wanted** — State verbs like 'want' take the past simple: 'wanted'.
8. **B. started** — The event that interrupts the game takes the past simple: 'started'.
9. **B. I was walking home when a dog suddenly barked at me.** — The walk (in progress) + the bark (sudden event) = past continuous + past simple.
10. **B. I was cooking when he called.** — 'I was cooking when he called' means the cooking was already happening.